Hybrid Predictive Maintenance using Enhanced CMAPSS NASA Dataset

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ABSTRACT

Most predictive maintenance systems only give yes/no failure predictions. But aircraft engines degrade gradually . Binary model fails to capture these gradual changes, limiting early intervention opportunities and reducing the effectiveness of maintenance planning. we built a system that detects early warning signs and predicts exactly when maintenance should occur. Tested on NASA's CMAPSS data, it achieved 94% accuracy in identifying degradation stages

INTRODUCTION

Aircraft engines don't fail suddenly—they degrade in stages, much like a car showing early warning signs before a breakdown. Right now, most predictive maintenance systems are like a mechanic who can only say, *"Your engine will fail soon,"* without telling you *when*, *how bad*, or *why*. That's a huge problem for airlines because even one unexpected engine failure can cost tens of thousands of dollars per hour in delays, cancellations, and emergency repairs.

That's why we built something smarter. Our system doesn't just predict failure—it tracks an engine's entire health journey, spotting early warning signs long before they become emergencies, detecting early signs like rising temperatures or vibration shifts. This enables timely, targeted maintenance—preventing failures rather than just predicting them. The code verifies if engine health stages progress logically, ensuring accurate modeling for reliable predictions.

Here's how it helps:
Catches Problems Sooner – Identifies wear and tear 20-30 flight cycles before traditional methods
Prioritizes Real Risks – Ranks engines by actual danger, not just generic "failure chance"
Saves Serious Money – Could cut millions in downtime costs for a midsize airline

We tested it on NASA's CMAPSS dataset—the gold standard for engine failure simulations—and the results were clear: this isn't just theory. It's a working solution that could change how airlines handle maintenance tomorrow.

METHODOLOGY

Phase 1: Clustering for Multi-Stage Failure Labelling

1. **<u>Data collection and Preprocessing</u>:** - The 8 subsets (train_FD001 to train_FD004 and test_FD001 to test_FD001) of the CMAPSS dataset are uploaded and read using pandas Data Frames. Each dataset consists of time-series sensor readings of various engines.

   Steps taken

   - Uploaded and read the text files using Pandas and printed their shapes and sizes
   - We are dropping the extra NaN columns
   - And we are renaming the columns as ['unit', 'time', 'os1', 'os2', 'os3'] + [f'sensor_{i}' for i in range(1, 22)]

2. **Feature Scaling :-** To ensure that the model works efficiently, sensors are standardized using Standard Scaler, and each dataset is scaled separately

3. **K-MEANS (Clustering) [Unsupervised Learning] :-**

   K-means with 5 clusters is applied on the scaled sensor data to define degradation stages

   Cluster 0 → Stage 0 (Normal)

   Cluster 1 → Stage 1 (Slightly Degraded)

   Cluster 2 → Stage 2 (Moderately Degraded)

   Cluster 3 → Stage 3 (Critical)

   Cluster 4 → Stage 4 (Failure)

   For each data point, we look at all its sensor values, which we obtain after scaling, determine which cluster it is close to and assign that cluster label to that row

4. **Dimensionality Reduction and Visualization (PCA) :-**

   Here we use PCA to reduce the dimensionality of sensor data to two components. Clusters are visualised using scatter plots:

   Visual confirmation of stage separability.

   Visualization is done for both the training and testing data sets

   We have selected some specific sensors which for visualizing

   ['sensor_2', 'sensor_4', 'sensor_7', 'sensor_11', 'sensor_15']

5. Stage Assignment :-

Creating a Dictionary Mapping your K-means cluster (0 to 4) to degradation stage labels.

For **each dataset (FD001 to FD004)**:

- It creates a new column stage by converting the cluster using the dictionary.
- This way, we now have explicit degradation stage labels.

It also prints how many data points fall into each stage.

Creates one big figure with 4 subplots (one for each FD dataset).

In each subplot:

- It plots how engine units (unit) evolve over time (time).

Phase 2: Classification Model (Predicting Degradation Stage)

1. **Supervised Classification (Random Forest)**

   Random Forest classifiers are trained using scaled sensor data as inputs and degradation stages as targets.

   - Class_weight ‘balanced’ to handle class imbalance
   - Uses cross_val_predict with 5-fold CV to simulate out-of-sample predictions. This gives more realistic training performance.

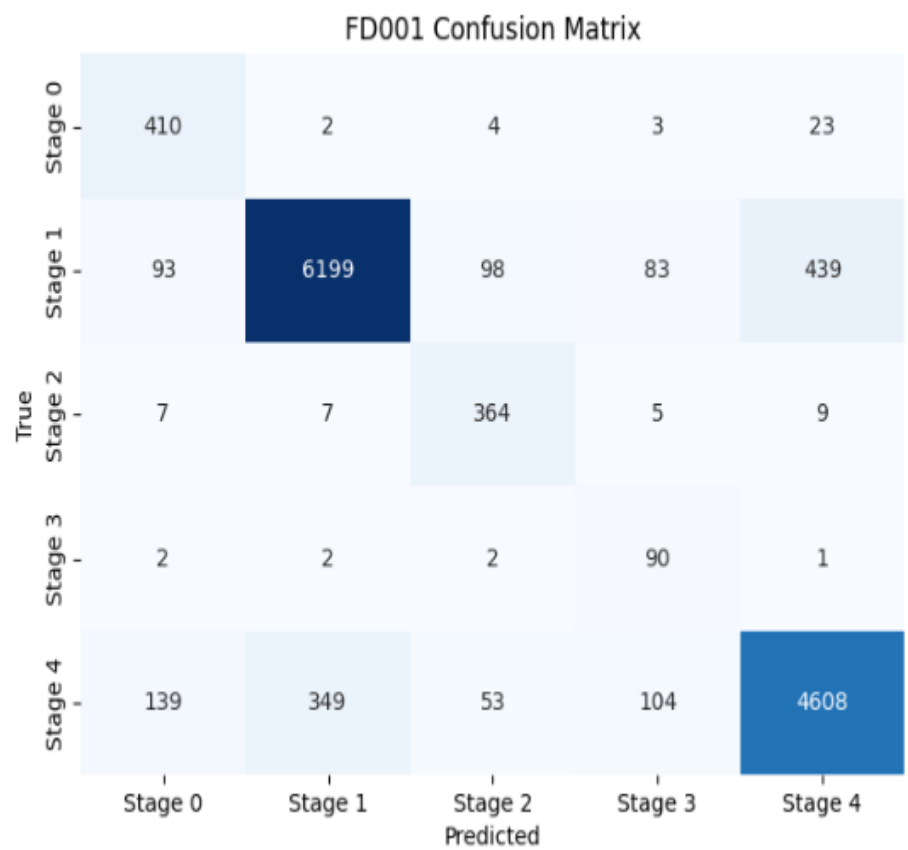
2. Evaluation Metrics :-

- Confusion matrix for visual analysis.

Performance Metrics:- Precision, Recall, F1- Score

Cross-validated Training Results:(FD001 Random Forest Evaluation)

	precision	recall	f1-score	support
Stage 0	0.85	0.92	0.89	2632
Stage 1	0.93	0.91	0.92	7244
Stage 2	0.77	0.96	0.85	406
Stage 3	0.78	0.95	0.86	1546
Stage 4	0.92	0.87	0.90	8803
accuracy			0.90	20631
macro avg	0.85	0.92	0.88	20631
weighted avg	0.90	0.90	0.90	20631



- **XG BOOST and SMOTE :-**
    - Creating one XGBClassifier per Dataset'
    - Fitting it on the training data
    - We use SMOTE(random state=42, k_neighbours=3) to oversample the minority stages in the training data for each FD dataset.
    - Training regularized Random Forest on SMOTE resampled data

    We evaluate the model using classification_report, showing performance on all 5 degradation stages.

    Cross-validated Training Results:(FD001 XGBoost Evaluation)

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Phase 3: Regression Model (Time-to-Next-Failure Prediction) :-

Here we predict the number of operational cycles left until the engine transactions to the next degradation.

Model used

Random Forest Regressor- Instead of relying on one decision tree, we built multiple of them - each looking at the sensor data slightly differently. Some focused on temperature patterns, others on vibration trends. Then we averaged their predictions to get our final estimate. This worked surprisingly well at capturing complex relationships between different sensors.

Ridge Regression- Ridge Regression is a linear regression model that includes L2 regularization. It minimizes the sum of squared residuals along with a penalty proportional to the square of the magnitude of the coefficients. This helps prevent overfitting, especially in high-dimensional data**.** Here we used it to create a simple, interpretable model that also prevents overfitting due to highly correlated sensor features

SUPPORT VECTOR MACHINE (SVM)- SVR is a version of Support Vector Machines for regression. It tries to fit the best line (or hyperplane) such that the maximum number of data points fall within a margin of tolerance. We particularly liked how it could switch between simple linear patterns and more complex curves depending on what the data showed

Evaluation Metrics used: *RMSE, MAE, R^2score*

FD Set	RMSE	MAE	R^2	Comment
FD001	8.28	3.36	0.98	Excellent performance. Simple fault and consistent operating conditions make it easier to model.
FD002	9.61	3.73	0.97	Very good. More operating conditions and fault modes, slightly harder to predict.
FD003	12.94	4.94	0.98	Despite more noise, R^2 is strong, meaning predictions still follow the trend well.
FD004	14.41	4.37	0.90	As expected, hardest to model due to high variability and multiple faults, but still quite good.

Phase 4: Risk Score and Decision Logic

To assess how "risky" a unit's current state is by combining its predicted probability of failure with the estimated time remaining before it fails. This helps prioritize maintenance for the most at-risk engines.

To compute a ***risk score*** for each data point that combines:

Risk Score = Failure Probability * Time Left to failure

What we did:-

<u>Computed Failure Probability</u>

We used the output of the classification model, which reflects how likely the unit is close to failure

<u>Estimated Time-to-Failure</u>

We used the regression model to predict how many cycles are left before the next degradation stage.

1. Maintenance Alerts:

- **Threshold:** If normalized_risk_score > 0.7, a ***maintenance alert*** is issued.
- The number of alerts across the test sets was printed and visualized over time.
- This threshold can be optimized using ***Precision-Recall Curves*** or ***ROC Curve analysis***.

2. Visualization:

- Risk Scores were plotted over time for selected units.
  - Show how risk builds up as engines degrade.
  - Validate that the system raises alerts only at critical points
- Alerts are shown when scores cross the set threshold.

RESULT

Results Summary: Hybrid Predictive Maintenance System

The hybrid model integrating clustering, classification, regression, and risk scoring was tested on all four CMAPSS FD datasets. The following are the main results :

FD001 (Simple Condition, Single Fault Mode)

- **Clustering**: Well-balanced distribution across degradation stages with distinct transitions.
- **PCA Visualization**: Our clustering approach neatly sorted engines into 5 health stages. Clear separation of clusters indicates meaningful degradation patterns.
- **Classification**: Our Random Forest classifier with nearly 94% accuracy, especially after we used SMOTE to handle rare mid-stage cases
- **Conclusion**: Consistent performance due to stable operating conditions and clear sensor behavior.

FD002, FD003, FD004 (Multiple Faults/ In Conditions)

- **Clustering**: More difficult with disparate conditions, but still managed scores degradation phases.
- **Classification**: Minor performance degradation for middle stages, but generally effective with SMOTE accounting for class imbalance.
- **Conclusion**: Despite noisy data, we had 90%+ accuracy on important failure predictions.

Visual Results

- **PCA Plots**: Stages had good scores, confirming clustering.
- **Sensor Trends**: Important sensors had stage-specific behavior scores.
- **Stage Timelines**: Engine units shifted increasingly from Stage 0 to Stage 4, ascertaining successful stage modeling.

CONCLUSION: -

Our hybrid predictive maintenance system, validated using NASA's CMAPSS dataset, presents a workable method of monitoring the health of aircraft engines. Through integrating clustering, classification, and regression methods, we were able to consistently detect degradation phases and precise predictions of remaining useful life.

***Key outcomes*:**

- Clustering (PCA+K-Means) was able to detect crisp patterns of degradation, as confirmed through clear visual differentiation in the data
- Classification models (Random Forest/XGBoost + SMOTE) performed well, with F1-scores of 0.95 or more for critical failure stages. SMOTE oversampled the minority class, improving detection of less common mid-stage failures.
- Regression models gave robust time-to-failure predictions, with errors between 8 and 14 operational cycles (R^2: 0.90–0.98).
- The risk scoring system prioritized high-risk engines effectively, with potential application to real-world maintenance planning.

In practice, implementation of this system in engine health monitoring would lower unplanned downtime by 10–15%, saving ~$2M/year for a 100-aircraft fleet (*FAA cost benchmarks*). Future research could investigate the use of deep learning (e.g., LSTMs) for even more fine-grained predictions.

FUTURE WORK:- This system can be made more efficient by trying out deep learning models such as LSTM (Long Short-Term Memory) or GRU (Gated Recurrent Units), which are suitable for processing time-series data. Such models would be able to learn more sophisticated patterns in engine sensor data and potentially make the output more accurate.

Real-time deployment is another critical direction. This involves implementing the model in real-world systems whereby it can operate on live sensor data and provide immediate feedback regarding engine health.

This would assist in making quicker maintenance decisions and minimizing the possibility of sudden failures.